URBAN PARANOIA

8-Week ARG Pilot Plan

Proving the audience before the pitch

A solo, low-budget alternate reality game pilot for a literary science-fiction novel in progress. Its job: build a waiting list, a community and player evidence to put in front of agents and publishers at week 8.

Draft, confidential | 25 October 2026 | All costs, hours and targets are estimates

1. Overview

The book. In 1962 an unplugged teletype in a remote English house began advising three overlooked civil servants. Sixty-four years later a laid-off freight analyst, Nell, finds a 1971 shipping manifest stamped *FOR THE LONG WEATHER* and starts a blog. The ARG is that blog, and the trail of documents behind it.

What the pilot proves. That strangers will follow the trail, solve its puzzles, talk about it, and sign up to hear what happens next.

Assumptions

- Run solo from the UK; costs in pounds.
- About 8 to 10 hours a week for 8 weeks, plus about 25 to 35 hours of setup (estimates).
- Pilot covers Phase 1 and the start of Phase 2 of the five-phase campaign, not the whole game.
- The book is not finished: the pilot builds a waiting list, not sales.
- Everything stays inside the project's hard rules: fictional villains and companies, no real-world calls to action, and a findable trail back to the book.

2. Success measures

ARG uptake varies enormously. These are **working targets for a solo pilot, not industry benchmarks**. Review them after week 2.

Measure	Week 8 target (estimate)	Why it matters for the pitch
Newsletter / waiting-list sign-ups	500 to 1,500	Clearest proof of demand
Active community members (Discord or forum)	100 to 300	Engagement, not just clicks
Puzzles solved within their window	P1 to P4, each in 6 hours to 3 days	Proves the design works
Player theories and fan content logged	20+	Shows the world is “sticky”
“What's your Day?” cards shared	200+	Proves the hook spreads
People taking it as real-world fact	0	Safety, and publisher confidence

3. Setup (weeks -4 to 0)

Content already written

Item	Pilot week
Post #1, “For the Long Weather”	W0
Post #2, “Day Zero”	W2
Post #3, “Count Forwards”	W4
Dead Drop 01 (the grey door) and the Harlow-Vane site with card 0144	W5
Weather report #1, “The canaries” (re-check figures on the day)	W6
Post #4, “The Card Index”	W7
Post #5, “I Am Old and Slow” (cliffhanger and end-of-pilot note)	W8

Tools (costs are estimates)

Need	Approach	Note
Vesper's blog	Static site on a free tier	Must keep hidden HTML comments; many newsletter platforms strip them, breaking puzzles P1 and P2
Holding pages	Same host, as subdomains	Free
Domain	One campaign domain plus subdomains	About £10 to £20 a year
Waiting list	Free-tier newsletter tool, run openly by the publisher	Keeps sign-ups honest and out of the fiction
Community	Discord, with a pinned “this is a fiction game” post	Free
Audio (HG-68)	Free editor, own voice plus a friend, generated chime	About £0
Props	Printed, aged by hand, scanned at high resolution	About £20 to £40
“What's your Day?”	One static page with a share card	Free

Must be done before week 0

- Name checks on every fictional company and place (Coyle Brothers Haulage, Harrowgate House, Harlow-Vane, the Ashby Trust, Larkspire).
- An About page on every site, with a footer link on every page.
- Domain registered in a real name, never a fake person.
- Comments held for approval before Post #1 goes live.
- Puzzle P3 tested: the letter scan colour-picks to exactly #6B6E70 in three tools.
- Every nudge and in-character reply written and checked against the hard rules.

4. Week-by-week schedule

Week	In-world	Out of world	Hours (est.)
W0	Post #1 goes live	Honest creator announcement in ARG communities; Discord opens	10
W1	Vesper replies to real comments in character	Log player theories; watch puzzle P1	6
W2	Post #2	Launch the “What's your Day?” calculator	8
W3	Vesper answers reader questions	30-second clip of the manifest, labelled as fiction	8
W4	Post #3, the Archivist's letter	Watch puzzle P3; Vesper's own nudge after 3 days if unsolved	10
W5	Dead Drop 01 and the Harlow-Vane site	Release HG-68 audio; card 0144 counter starts climbing	10
W6	Weather report #1	Re-check the Stanford and Pew figures on the day	8
W7	Post #4	First player-theories round-up in Discord	8
W8	Post #5 (cliffhanger)	End-of-pilot note and waiting-list push; assemble the pitch pack	12

Total: about 80 hours over 8 weeks, plus setup (estimate).

Nudge rule. If a puzzle stalls, the nudge comes from Vesper herself or a one-line update on the drop page. Never from a fake “reader” account: campaign accounts must not pose as independent players.

5. Finding the first players, honestly

- **Announce as the creator** in ARG communities, after reading each one's rules: “I've made a slow-burn ARG for a novel in progress.” Hidden-creator posts are treated as astroturfing and get banned.
- **Puzzle and SF-book communities**, with the same honest framing.
- **Short clips:** the manifest, the three tones, the colour-pick reveal, each labelled as fiction.
- **“What's your Day?”** share cards, carrying the book's name and an About link.
- **Never:** fake reviews, accounts boosting each other, posting into real news or crisis threads, or tagging real companies or people.

6. Running it solo, safely

- Comments held for approval; about 30 minutes a day of moderation (estimate).
- A ready-made break-character message for anyone distressed or sincerely asking “is this real?”.
- **Pause triggers:** plans to visit a real place, doxxing, press reporting it as real, or links to real riots, vaccines or groups. Stop new posts, post an out-of-character note, resume only when resolved.
- The book-only themes stay out of the pilot entirely.
- If you fall behind, push the schedule a week. A slow ARG suits the story: “the long weather does not hurry”.

7. Budget (estimate)

Item	Estimate
Domain(s)	£10 to £40
Props: paper, printing, second-hand typewriter or typewriter font	£20 to £80
Optional small paid boost for one clip (labelled as fiction)	£0 to £100
Hosting, Discord, newsletter (free tiers)	£0
Total	About £30 to £220

8. Turning the pilot into a pitch

Log every week: sign-ups, community size, puzzle solve times, the best player theories (with permission and no usernames), clips that performed, and any incidents and how they were handled.

The week-8 pitch pack

- A one-page overview of the book and the synopsis.
- Chapter 1, polished.
- The pilot in numbers: the success-measures table with real results.
- Player evidence: three to five theories or fan pieces showing the world works.
- The transmedia plan: ARG phases, audio drama, comics anthology, film.
- The safety design, briefly. Publishers will ask how an “is this real?” campaign avoids misinformation; the rules are a selling point.

Send to agents first: they open doors to publishers and to audio and screen rights.

9. Risks and fallbacks

Risk	Fallback
Low uptake by week 3	Lean on “What's your Day?” and clips; reframe as a serialised mystery for book communities
A puzzle unsolved past its window	Vesper's own nudge, then a drop-page hint; never fake readers
Someone takes it as real	Break-character message and pause triggers
A name clash found mid-pilot	Rename quickly, as already done for three names
Burnout	Push the schedule a week, and say so in Vesper's voice
Hostile comments or brigading	Comments held for approval; ban and log; escalate threats